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Loren Schoenberg

Loren Schoenberg has distinguished himself in the jazz world as a tenor saxophonist, band leader, jazz educator, and Director of the Jazz Museum of Harlem.

He was interviewed in New York City on January 14, 2019 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

@5:00

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive. I'm very pleased to have Loren Schoenberg here today. And I read through your resume, it only took a half an hour.

LS: Bu-dump-bump.

MR: Bu-dump-bump is right. But all the things you've done, I don't like to bring myself into this but I can personally relate to cause I've done a few of them and I know they have required different talents. You started out playing the piano, right? Did you have a point in your teens where you said to yourself dammit, I'm going to be a musician. I'm going to make a living as a musician?

LS: Well I don't know how to say it. It was almost like pre-ordained or natural for me that this happened. I'm the youngest of three children and sometimes I think the youngest child they say is spoiled or has more options because maybe the parents had other experiences with the older children or something like that. So I evinced a talent for music early on, not a great talent but just I loved to play and I was always playing. And my high school band director had been a music theory major at Manhattan School of Music. And I really kind of cottoned to music theory, for whatever reason, and maybe because he was a great teacher in high school, and we had music theory. This was a normal high school, this was not an arts school, it was just Fairlawn High School in Bergen County, New Jersey, and somehow the career that my band director had had of becoming a music theory major, he had gone to Manhattan School of Music, somehow I kind of fell into that, that that was going to become my goal. And then there were no jazz degrees in those days, not really jazz programs so to speak. Juilliard had no jazz whatsoever, and Manhattan School of Music did have a good jazz band led by Rusty Dedrick, and a good faculty, and so I wound up being accepted to Manhattan School of Music. I guess we're jumping ahead a little bit here. But I wound up being accepted there in 1976 as a theory major and piano minor. But the funny thing was that my parents, you know my parents were very supportive. I never even contemplated doing anything else. And they let me do that. It wasn't as though well, like a lot of, I mean there was a kid lived down the street

wonderful piano, and he was a year younger than me, than I. And so but his parents made him get a law degree. And I think that was probably how it was for most kids, but it wasn't like that for me.

MR: Yeah. They want you to have the, even if you go into music some of them want you to have the fall-back-on.

LS: Right.

MR: Right? Get that teaching degree or whatever.

LS: Right. So that was a real leap of faith on my parents I guess. I was very lucky with my parents, which I can tell you more about.

MR: Did you — were you turned on by the Swing Era music, and then the jazz that was being played at the time?

LS: No. It's all because of my father had a 78, a Decca 78 album of "The Jolson Story" with two pictures of white gloves on the cover. No picture of Jolson or anything like that. And I fell in love with his voice and phrasing. Now I was a strange kid, I mean I'm four years old and this is 1962 and I loved these records. And I used to imitate them, it was kind of strange for a little kid. And that got me into, I mean I was already kind of like — you know I should tie up the Jolson thread just for a moment, that the whole thing about minstrelsy and African-American culture actually wound up getting a head start, my being attracted to Al Jolson and then eventually having to come to terms with minstrelsy in general and Jolson in specific, who's gotten a very rough deal. He's become kind of like the straw man for talking about minstrels. It was just very unfair to him. But so unwittingly I was set into something that was going to force me to confront, you know, the overwhelming issue of America and that's as W.E.B. DuBois put it so many years ago, race. So that pretty much everything I've done in my life has been somehow, in some sense been connected with those questions. But I went from there, I was a collector. I used to write NASA and get things about Gemini VI and Gemini, the little home film of the docking and all this kind of stuff. So I was that kind of kid who wanted to write letters and wanted to research things, for whatever, and then, because I wanted to see Al Jolson and then eventually I wanted to see old movies and I wanted to see old Warner Brothers films that were at theaters in New York City like the Theater 80 St. Marks and others, this would be the early 70s, that were showing old movies. And my parents, God Bless them, would bring me in from the suburbs and watch these old movies, which they weren't particularly interested in. They had seen them when they came out and they weren't at all interested in nostalgia or anything like that. And then I started seeing Ruby Keeler and Dick Powell and those movies and I kind of loved that stuff. And I was already going buying records and records in the local public library. And then eventually

sudden I got this bug about oh boy, well all that other stuff was great but boy there's something about that that really gets me. Well my local public library had a copy of Benny Goodman's 1938 Carnegie Hall concert, a double LP, which influenced so many people of a certain age. And I fell in love with it. And I just loved listening to it. And at that point I had been taking — I started piano lessons when I was 4. And you know, a typical thing, an old lady who lived on my little street who had like a living room with heavy drapes — I mean it was your typical whatever that experience was you know. You felt like everyone was looking at you and you sat there and you played in the dark drapes and the old lady and the whole thing. But it worked well, you know what I mean? Not interested in jazz at all or anything like that, but I learned basic the Hanon whatever the heck it was.

MR: The Hanon exercises.

LS: Right. And John Thompson, "A Day in Bermuda" or whatever they called it. "A snowy Bird" you know, and learned all that stuff. And then, on this Benny Goodman record I listened to it and I looked at all the names and then in my local newspaper, the *Bergen Evening Record* I saw, I was about, I don't know, 13 or 14, and it said, "Sundays at the Colonial Post on Main Street in Hackensack, New Jersey, Sundays maybe 5 PM to 8 PM Teddy Wilson." And I said this cannot be the Teddy Wilson who's on the Benny Goodman record I'm listening to at Carnegie Hall. I mean what would he be doing playing at an Italian restaurant in Hackensack, New Jersey? Well it turns out that Teddy lived in New Jersey as did Hank Jones, in Bergen County, and when he was around he took whatever gigs he could get just to keep his fingers in shape and maybe he was in between tours or whatever. And so my parents took me to see him and he was very kind and let me sit by the piano and look and all this kind of stuff. I mean I really had no inkling of what I was getting. I mean I knew he was great but all I knew was this one record and that I loved the music. And so my parents got to meet him. And that started a series of things where my parents would meet these musicians, now let's put it in context. I mean these are African-American musicians. I'm a kid growing up in the 60s and 70s in Bergen County, New Jersey, which was one of the most un-diverse places there could be, although my town, called Fairlawn, was kind of unusual because it had a large Jewish population. On the day that my parents moved in in the 1950s to welcome the first Jewish family on the block everyone put up For Sale signs on all the houses, so they saw that as they drove up the first day. Then they took the signs down. So you know it was not a very diverse place. So what happened was my parents met Teddy Wilson and eventually met Hank Jones and eventually met Eddie Durham and a few other people who were so avuncular and so warm and supportive, my parents said we have no problem at all with

to be a jazz musician and he's going to be hanging out with these people with all the prejudices about, forget race for a moment, just about how jazz musicians are. I mean my parents were just normal, when I say normal people what I mean is they didn't know anything about show biz or musicians.

MR: He's going to work in bars and live the night life.

LS: Well, and all the negative connotations that again, due to race, that came to, you know as we find out that more, you know, physicians have problems with drugs than musicians, and that you know musicians are actually way down on the line. But anyway so you asked earlier about like when I knew I was going to be a musician — I think all these experiences kind of led to them. My parents saw like oh wow, there's these wonderful mentors out there and they're willing to answer Loren's questions or something like that. And so that's kind of part of the context.

MR: That's terrific.

LS: Thanks.

MR: You mentioned minstrel-y, you know, the minstrel practice.

LS: Minstrelsy.

MR: Minstrelsy, thank you.

LS: Right. Still very prevalent in 2019. It is.

MR: This is a hard — maybe a hard or way too simplistic question. But you teach jazz history, do you think that the development of the music has more to do with sociology or to do with musicology?

LS: Oh sociology, hands down.

MR: Okay.

LS: Because I mean, I'm a college dropout so let's get that straight. So I don't know a lot of terms to be conversant with necessarily, and I might be confusing some that someone with an academic background might hear me talking and right now they're rolling their eyes. But what I mean is that — well you mentioned teaching jazz history. We don't get to Jelly Roll Morton or Sidney Bechet for a couple of months. So you know it's all about New Orleans and English and French mercantilism, and what it was like to be colonized by the French or by the English or by the Spanish, and about of course New Orleans and about the great lives of the nineteenth century and about Gottschalk, Louis Moreau Gottschalk, and about Abe Lincoln and, all these things, and without laying a strong predicate or whatever the right word would be for that, then I don't think you can really start to understand, I should say not you of course but a young student of 2019 who may not be enmeshed in history like earlier generations were, that it's necessary to create this context. And then maybe we can start to understand who Armstrong was and who Bechet

lot from reading Albert Murray and then getting to know him and Stanley Crouch and others, and just doing a lot of reading and talking to people, including musicians of the much older generations. I mean I got to know Zutty Singleton's wife pretty well, which I'll talk about when we talk about the New York Jazz Museum, and trying to put it all together in some way that makes sense. So I don't know if that answered your question.

MR: It did. Okay. You just returned from the Jazz Ed conference?

LS: Jazz Education something.

MR: Yeah. Jazz network thing, in Reno.

LS: Yeah it was great.

MR: Now when you're out there and being surrounded with all those people and activity you might get one feeling about the state of jazz. When you come back here and you live here and you participate and you observe the jazz scene, do you get a different take on today's state of jazz?

LS: Well I wouldn't say I get two different ones, they're all part of one. It's like not mirror images but it's so inspiring going to those jazz conventions. I mean it's just wonderful because you see what the music means to so many people who don't live in New York or don't live near the major metropolitan areas where there are jazz clubs. And these are the people that are keeping the flame alive in everywhere else in the country. And to see how the kids are so excited and all this kind of stuff, and they're going to play their tune and they're going to do this and they're going to do that without realizing, and this kind of merges a little bit with your previous question, merging with American history. Every time you pick up an instrument to play jazz or to contemplate it, you're part of some tradition, you're following in footsteps, you know, defined by African-American geniuses. And you're part of the story and it's a great heritage. And it's a heritage that you know is participated in by something that is for most of the time, fun, and playing an instrument and tapping your foot, and so it's kind of profound. I mean it's easy to look at jazz education or things like that less than charitably sometimes, when you realize that a large percentage of people who teach that never played in a band or never really had experience, I don't find that very satisfying at the end of the day as not the proper way, but it's how I look at it. I look at it, it's all good. This is wonderful. These are people that love the music, we've got to support them and get to them however we can get to them. And a big problem with teaching, as I'm sure you know and we all know or as parents know, I'm not a parent, but that you can't teach kids in 2019 assuming that they are like we were in 1976 or 1986 or as your students were in '96 or '06. It doesn't work. And so consequently you know you've got to learn to adapt. And so that's how I come back from the JEN convention in Reno, I heard some great music, I met some wonderful teachers, I

people loving it. And I come back to New York and of course I'm very involved with the Jazz Museum and keeping an institution alive, and so yeah, it's all part of one big picture.

MR: It's all good.

LS: I don't have a summation kind of thing, but I'm just again going back to something I wanted to say was I'm probably the luckiest person. You know some people say well there's luck but there's also this and that and being in the position to have luck or something like that. Nonetheless I am among the luckiest people that you're ever going to interview.

MR: All right. I consider myself pretty lucky too. And at one point I had had, because I was in the right place at the right time I got to ride to a gig with the Statesmen of Jazz, and like Milt Hinton was on my left, and he fell asleep on my shoulder. And I'm thinking, this is Milt Hinton and I'm with him, and Panama Francis and Claude Williams, and I'm just like, said to myself, you should really take note of this and appreciate it. So I'm wondering if you had that same feeling. You played beside, you know, Eddie Durham and Panama I mentioned and Russell Procope and — were you aware of the significance of that I guess it is if I have a question.

LS: To the degree that a 19-year-old can, or a 25-year-old. Yeah. I mean if you want to work biographically up to how all those things happened, so I'm back in New Jersey, you know, and I'm a teenager, and my parents are meeting some of these people and I'm hearing Teddy Wilson and then Hank Jones also was playing solo piano at a place called the Sherry Netherlands and I used to go there. My parents would leave me and Hank would drive me home. Was I appreciating it as to what it really was? How could I? I was 16 years old. I knew that this was a great man and that I was very lucky to be around him. Now I look back at it and I'm like Jesus. But what happened was there was something in New York called the New York Jazz Museum. How I learned about it I don't remember except I would have read about it in the paper. This was 1972. So I was 14, or turning 14 that summer. And I don't know how it happened. I guess I read about it. I asked my parents to take me in. They took me in and I wanted to volunteer. And I wound up becoming a volunteer at this place as it opened. It was on West 55th Street between 6th and 7th, right just east of the City Center. And it was in an old carriage house that had been owned by the Rockefellers many, many years before. And there was a woman named Evelyn Cunningham who was a real figure in New York civil rights history, who worked for Nelson Rockefeller. And somehow between her and some other people they arranged for this to become a jazz museum. It was a long, it's kind of like the shape of our place up in Harlem now, kind of a long, rectangular space. Not that big but it went back pretty deep. And the man ran it named Jack Bradley. And Jack, this was now 1972. Louis

friends with Bobby Hackett and he was like an adopted son of Louis's, of Louis Armstrong, and a lifelong disciple of his. And he wound up becoming the manager of this small little jazz museum. And he took me on as a volunteer. So every Saturday and Sunday I would take the bus — you could take a bus from suburban New Jersey into New York, it was easy, and my parents let me do it, unbelievable. And I wound up volunteering there for years. And this is where I got to know Marge Singleton, Zutty Singleton's wife, it's where I got to know Clarence Armstrong, who was Louis Armstrong's, I guess he was a cousin, he was mentally challenged. In those days they used the word slow or retarded. I don't know what the right term is. But he was kind of like a big child. And because Jack was so close with Louis and the family he would spend weekends there. A little bit later Duke Ellington was — we didn't know but he was dying in the hospital so Harry Carney came in, and Harold Ashby used to come in and spend weekends just hanging around this jazz museum, so I got to know all these people. There was an opening of an exhibit on Count Basie and I brought my little — at that time I had a hand-held cassette machine that was about this big, you remember, that you press the button like this, and I remember bringing it in and I tape recorded on a cassette the first opening night. And it was Eddie Durham, Buddy Tate, Al Gray, Chuck Folds on piano, Eddie Jones on bass and Jo Jones on drums, and a few others who I got to know later. And Paul Quinichette was there. And then, who comes in but Basie. So Basie plays the piano. Then who muscles his way through the crowd — now Eddie Jones if you remember, I think you interviewed him.

MR: Not the bassist.

LS: Not the bassist. Eddie Jones was about six feet — he could have been a football player — like six foot six, big guy. Somebody comes and taps him on the shoulder and takes the bass. It's Charles Mingus. And I recorded this on my little tape. I gave it to Phil Schaap, I never saw it again, but I'm just joking because Phil gave it back to me thirty years later.

MR: Okay.

LS: But anyway, but, so I was around these things. With the Jazz Museum, in the back they had a projection room where we would show films every Saturday or Sunday afternoon and my job as a 14 or 15-year-old was to actually thread them, you know the old fashioned thing, thread the movie into the camera and show it, and we would show "The Sound of Jazz" and we would show "Jammin' the Blues." So I saw these things, I don't know, a hundred times or more by the time I was 15 or 16. I had many, many experiences at the Jazz Museum. Jack Bradley at that time was really kind of — and I met Dan Morgenstern at that time because Dan was on the board of the Jazz Museum. And we joke about it now because we've been friends for, you know, almost 50 years, which is

kid just pestering him all the time you know. And so I met him there. And then we had an exhibit on Benny Goodman. And I was a Benny Goodman fanatic already based on having that record at the public library, and I had started corresponding with D. Russ Conner. We called him Russ Conner. Russ Conner was the guy who wrote *BG on the Record*, which is the first, excuse me, was the first biodiscography. Again it sounds like something you go to the doctor for.

MR: Yeah, they treat you for that.

LS: But that was a combination of a biography and a discography. And he had a book out called *BG on the Record* Benny Goodman on the Record. And I found it in a local library and I started writing him post cards about like where can I find the alternate take of "House Hop" or something like this. Because in those days it was hard to find, I mean there's no internet, there's no nothing in the record stores and all this kind of stuff, and so I was very much enmeshed in collecting and getting to meet the musicians who had worked with Goodman. Well when we were preparing for the Goodman exhibit, Hymie Shertzer came in and Hymie had been the lead alto player in Benny Goodman's band back in the 30s. And he really couldn't believe that like some kid knew who he was. And someone else came into the Jazz Museum, and I can't remember his name but he was on WBAI radio, here in New York, a Pacifica station. And they did really kind of like esoteric programming and very leftish at that time. And somehow he said would you like — it was kind of weird to find this 14, 15-year-old kid that wants to hear this old music. I came on his radio show just to talk about the Jazz Museum and he offered me a little — a few shows of my own. So I interviewed Hymie Shertzer and then I interviewed Ray Nance when I was about 15 or so. And I said some of the stupidest things. I have a cassette of it somewhere, just horrible. You'll never hear them. But the bottom line was so already this interest in history — so I met Benny Goodman at that exhibit thing when I was 15, and around the same time, when we were going to hear Teddy Wilson play with my parents, Teddy was playing at a place called the Cookery, which was at 9th Street and University Place, which was owned by Barney Josephson, who used to own Café Society. And then in the early 70s he had Alberta Hunter made her comeback at this club, and Teddy Wilson played there, and all kinds of people. Well my parents took me down to see Teddy Wilson one night, this is all happening in these years. And Teddy had a tuxedo on, and the date, I'm not one of those date people but I happen to remember it because I can picture it, it's either 1972 or '73. I think it was '72. And Teddy is dressed in a tuxedo which he never wore. I said, "Oh Mr. Wilson, why are you wearing a tuxedo." He said well they're giving a — the National Urban League is giving an award to Lionel Hampton tonight at the Waldorf, and I'm going from here to there, and we're re-uniting

know I said oh my God, you know. He went, "Well would you like to come with me." "Would I like to come with you?" But then how am I going to — my father is going to have to drive back and leave me for three or four hours and then either go back to Fairlawn or go sit somewhere, and I went with Teddy Wilson and I got autographs. It was Lionel Hampton, Gene Krupa, Benny Goodman, Lionel Hampton, Illinois Jacquet played with them, and I think it was George Duvivier or Slam Stewart. And I got all these autographs. And that was the first time that I met Goodman and then when he came to the Jazz Museum I said well I had got your autograph, as though he would remember you know. And he said well maybe you want to come — and I wanted an autographed picture. He said, "Well call my office." So I called his office and it was on a weekend or something, I went in and it was a woman named Muriel Zuckerman, who had been Benny Goodman's personal aide for 40 years, like a real Girl Friday kind of thing. She was in love with the boss and a wonderful woman. And I went in and I got this autograph of Benny Goodman, little did I know that I would be running that office several years later. So this is all just giving context to what happened to me before I went to college. Then also in New Jersey there was a jazz workshop at a place called Ramapo College. And it was one of the first I think serious like jazz like summer jazz workshop kind of thing for kids. This was in the early 70s, mid 70s. And it was run by a man named Harold Lieberman, a wonderful trumpet player. He did some studio work. And he had an assistant working for him by the name of Dick Lowenthal. And so they had this wonderful program. And among the faculty were Frankie Dunlop, the drummer who played with Thelonious Monk, Bucky Pizzarelli, Derek Smith, and oh man there was someone else who I just am blanking on, Paul Jeffrey, the saxophone player. And Kenny Washington, I met him there, he was on this thing. And so I was very lucky, when I said about luck, you know because at that time kind of like a burgeoning of jazz education for kids, the Jazz Museum happened to start in New York, Teddy Wilson happened to have a weekend off from playing in Hackensack, New Jersey, and all these things are just coming together. Well I fell in love with the Benny Goodman record at Carnegie Hall, and for whatever reason I zeroed in on this tenor sax solo that Lester Young played on that concert. And I had taken a couple of clarinet lessons, never got very far on it, but at least I learned the fingering. And there was a tenor sax in the high school band room. And I kind of taught myself to play it. I mean it's not hard to teach yourself the saxophone if you've taken a couple of clarinet lessons. I mean it's very simple fingering and much simpler than the clarinet.

MR: Yes, more friendly.

LS: And so I picked it up and slowly began this move towards not focusing exclusively on the

MR: At 15 years of age.

LS: About 15 or so. Yeah. And one last thing that was probably a real key component of all these things in terms of getting into school and becoming more professional was that at the Jazz Museum one of Jack Bradley's closest friends was the cornetist Ruby Braff. And Ruby was a real character and I eventually became his personal manager and that's another story. But Ruby heard me play the piano at the museum, as much as I could play, and he kind of said you know it's pretty bad he says, but you know you've got some potential there. You really should study with this guy named Sanford Gold, who was kind of a legendary — well I didn't know — kind of a legendary piano teacher in New York in the 60s, 70s, maybe 50s, 60s, 70s, and all kinds of people studied with him from A to Z classical, jazz, he taught technique but he also married the study of the piano into theory. So as you learned — I mean he didn't teach beginning players but as you learned to play this Chopin etude or as you learned to play "Waltz for Debby" or whatever it was, you were mapping out the harmonic sphere. And he had his own system of diminished chords and substitution chords and all this kind of stuff. It was pretty good. And so I studied with — so what happened was he charged $25 a lesson. This was 1973 or so. And that was unheard of. I mean I was taking piano lessons in Ridgewood, New Jersey for, I don't know, for $5 or $10. And my parents were really skeptical. And one day when my dad came to pick me up at the Jazz Museum Ruby came out with Jack Bradley and they talked to my father. My dad didn't know who Ruby Braff was except that Jack probably said he's a great musician. He said, "Mr. Schoenberg, you know, your son has some talent but he's really not too good but if he has any potential he should go with Sanford Gold, it's $25." And he said, "I'm sorry but we can't, we're not going to do that." And Ruby and Jack said, "Well we'll pay for it then." Now whether they really would have or not I don't know, it doesn't make a difference. But the gesture of having said that convinced my parents that I should study with Sanford Gold and that is probably the most significant thing that happened to me in between playing the piano at four years old and getting into Manhattan School of Music as a piano minor, third year piano minor when I was 17 or 18. Because Sanford Gold could hear wrong fingering. He could hear wrong fingering. And it's not just me saying it, he was famous for it. He'd be in another part of the room facing another way while you were playing, and he'd say, "Second finger." I mean he could tell from the articulation of the note. Now also studying with him at that time were Jon Faddis and Lew Soloff, who were both new in New York and roommates I guess, or very close friends, and they were studying with him. They couldn't have been, I mean Jon is not that much older than me, he was probably 19 or something. And I remember they were crazy and I remember meeting other people in those days at his

studio. So if you put all that together it starts to give you a picture of where I was when I went to college.

MR: You went to college before you went to college.

LS: Yes. You know that's a good —

MR: That's the way I feel about it. Because you can't pay for that stuff that you got.

LS: Absolutely. A question you asked a while ago was like did I realize or did I know like you mentioned you were in a car with Milt Hinton over here asleep on your shoulder. You're saying now wait a minute, this is not just some old bass player, this is Milton J. Hinton and this is Fiddler Claude Williams or these people. And the only way to answer your question is you know you were older when that happened to you, I assume you were in your 30s or something.

MR: Yes.

LS: For me in my teens frankly I thought that's the way the life was. And I mean I treated them with great respect. Of course I think now about how I behaved and I go oh my God. But no I mean I had no idea of how great it was.

MR: Yeah. In some ways it's great. I mean when I was in my teens I had a couple of experiences but they were a different level, like Chuck and Gap Mangione in Rochester.

LS: Oh. Yeah.

MR: Okay? So that was my thing. And at the time it was the same. I was respectful, I was a little envious, they're doing what I would like to do. But and then later on when you know the history of these people. So that's a heck of a story. Jazz has been called America's only original art form.

LS: When you transcribe this you can transcribe that I'm going to roll my eyes.

MR: Okay. Well I'm rolling mine too and I'm off camera.

LS: He's off camera, okay.

MR: But what about the blues?

LS: What about the blues?

MR: What about the blues? Isn't the blues its own original American art form?

LS: Yeah. I guess so, yeah.

MR: Okay. Why did you roll your eyes?

LS: Because there's two things that I roll my eyes at, and I roll them in great respect. I mean, and he did roll his eyes, that those kind of statements I don't know how much good they do. I don't know how much light they shed on anything, because well what about cartoons? What about a certain kind of cinema? What about any number of things that are uniquely American. I mean early on Albert Murray had me read a book called *American Humor* by Constance Rourke, it was written back around 1930 or so. And you start to see

and part African-American and part Yankee and part Dutch and part Asian and all these kind of things. And you start to realize early on that the one and only kind of thing doesn't really work. And the other statement that we can just get it out of the way that I also really roll my eyes at is that jazz is America's classical music, and also jazz was America's popular music at one time, which it never was. So those are the three oft-repeated canards, moldy canards that kind of get me going you know. But yeah.

MR: Now I can use it. Hey next time you see Loren, want to see him roll his eyes? Just try this one on him.

LS: And you can take that little video clip of me and just loop it.

MR: Yeah.

LS: But anyway, but yeah.

MR: Yeah the first time I saw jazz is America's classical music was in the context of another person saying, "Please, let's not call it that. Do you want it to be treated like classical music is treated?" Do you want it to be shown only — I mean the whole routine.

LS: Yeah. And let's not forget you know that Ellington and Dizzy Gillespie and Max Roach and Fletcher and many other people wanted to get rid of the word "jazz" early on. But that's not so much about my biography. But, but these are important things to talk about. I mean frankly, Monk, I mean if this was another context I would love to interview — right now I'm kind of dying to know what you think about all these things. No, but I mean it. I'm serious. Because you've taught and you've been around for a long time and have the benefit of this incredible archive of interviews that I haven't said, I'm proud to be asked to be a member of. And I'm not being unctuous here. I've spent quite a bit of time watching them. I will look at them for a while then I'll go back and go oh my God look at this and I'll look at one that I didn't want to look at another time. And I've learned a lot from them. So I would love to hear your take on all this stuff too.

MR: Well don't you usually think that, usually explaining things and putting them in context historical and otherwise is usually left to the people who are not doing it. The people that are doing it think less about where is my work fitting in to the timeline and the whole development thing. They're doing it because they're driven, and then years later it will get sorted out but not by them but by somebody else.

LS: Yeah. Well some of them were very conscious of it and some of them did see it all.

MR: Like who would you say?

LS: John Lewis, Benny Carter, Duke Ellington for starters, Dizzy Gillespie, Max Roach, Wynton Marsalis.

MR: Okay.

LS: You know. But I think that part of that is — just let me think for one second — well, the thought went out of my head, it's okay. If you wanted me to pick up the story of my life kind of thing?

MR: Well I have a question about maybe here's a scenario: you're at a cocktail party and you know in conversation it comes up that you're in jazz, and someone says, "Well jazz, I just don't get it. When they start doing that whatever they do I guess they're making it up. I don't get it." Do you have anything that you can offer that person to help them?

LS: Yeah sure. Ninety, over ninety-five out of a hundred people that I meet, if it comes up that I'm a jazz musician or a jazz person or somehow involved with jazz and this is not hyperbole, it's literal, way over ninety-five percent over the last forty years, "Oh I'm a jazz saxophone player." "Really? You know I don't know a lot about jazz – I don't know a lot about jazz, I like some of it" or I don't like it, but they always say I really don't know anything. And this has really been a huge benefit to me in terms of trying to comprehend how to teach it and also how to try and build an institution like the Jazz Museum. So my first response is, "Let me ask you a question. When you go to a restaurant and order salmon, do you say to the waiter, 'I'll have the salmon please, you know I don't know much about salmon. I really don't know much about it but I'd like to order it.'" You don't feel compelled to express your ignorance. But something about the way that jazz has evolved leads the great majority of people to express ignorance. And that's a huge red flag and that's something that is incumbent upon all of us to deal with, to try and de-stigmatize it. It's been stigmatized and that's a fact.

MR: Stigmatized how?

LS: That there's something to know that I don't know. There's nothing to know about jazz. There's nothing to know about eating a piece of salmon. There's nothing to know about, you know, walking down the street. There's nothing to know about it. You like it or you don't like it. And if you can let go of the preconceptions, if you like it and if you're curious, maybe you'll want to know more about it. But there's nothing to know. I mean Jesus, there's nothing to know about, I mean think of some of the most basic functions that we do for enjoyment in life. I mean you know when you first got into it was it because you wanted to learn something? I don't think so. And in terms of enjoying art I really think it's exactly the same way. Then you want to study it. Oh this happened, I didn't like or I did like — well talk to somebody else about it. I heard this kind of jazz, boy I liked that but I didn't like this. So it's been hugely stigmatized.

MR: I love that. Because I've had people say, "I don't like jazz, I don't understand it. I like Beethoven." And I feel like saying, "Do you understand Beethoven? What do you understand about Beethoven that makes you like it?"

MR: And I wouldn't be that sarcastic but I like what you say.

LS: Well my thing isn't sarcastic.

MR: No, I, yeah.

LS: It's very sincere. Do you think about, when you talk about a food you like, do you say that I don't know anything about it but I'd like to order it? And when you listen to music I mean what happened in jazz that got to the point where over nine out of ten people have to say I don't know much about it. It's insane.

MR: Is it because now it's high art?

LS: I think it's — I don't know. That's possible. I think part of it is that, okay getting back to what we talked about quite a while ago, so the overwhelming headline in talking about anything about jazz and all this part of this conversation which we're having, which is not biographical so much as about the state of jazz, you know there's this looping headline all the time, which is race, okay? So let's keep that in mind as it's floating behind our heads while we're talking. Okay. So what is it about jazz, how did this evolve? Well let's look at it this way. There was a great, there was a great lie in the nineteenth century. And the lie is you've got to watch out for the male, for the black slave, because he's going to escape and rape all the white women. Of course these prejudices are very much present in a lot of popular music today and in a lot of the racial hang-ups in our country in many ways. Now where does that come from? It comes from the fact that the truth is in the nineteenth century that the great amount of sexual shenanigans and crimes were committed by white slave owners against slaves, or enslaved people, depending on which term you prefer to use, okay. To cover up from the shame of that lie through minstrelsy and many, many other forms of popular entertainment, Americans to assuage that feeling of horrible guilt created the African-American male as a asexual cartoonish buffoonish kind of figure. All one has to do is watch Spike Lee's film "Bamboozled" which we watch in my jazz history class sometimes, along with "Rashomon" but that's another story. Okay. So to compensate for that feeling of guilt and that feeling of responsibility a certain type of minstrelsy evolves. Now eventually, white appropriation not withstanding, jazz evolves to the point where the French are taking it seriously and the European, other European countries are taking it intellectually and seriously, and America at some point, and boy I'm glossing over so much here, and culturally eventually says you know we should be proud of jazz. People all around the world say it's so serious, we should be — and guess what we're going to do? We're going to take it out of its natural milieu, which would be like what John Batiste calls his band, Social Music, and what I think Louis Armstrong used terms like that, maybe even Ellington. Social music. It was somehow integrated with social functions, and not something abstract that one listens to like this,

let me back up for a moment. I don't mean we killed it by putting it in the concert hall, that's a gloss. What I mean to say is that by taking it away from dancing and by taking it away from good times, what Albert Murray writes about in *Stomping the Blues* and many, many other places, there was a price to be paid. And the price that was paid that it found its place in the concert hall. Now you might ask yourself the question of why do people, especially in America, but why do we behave the way that we behave in the concert hall, listening to classical music? I mean it's the strangest thing in the world, right? And I won't go into — I have a long rap about this I do when I'm teaching and I'm sure you do too. But you know the behavior in the concert hall. The opening of the wrapper. The people who are asleep. The people that have no idea what the hell they're listening to except they feel like they're eating their spinach and they're going to see a concert. And they don't really — the great majority of them I don't think are that engaged in it. Okay. Now we put jazz in there and take it away from its roots. I think the Ellington band probably had the healthiest diet of Carnegie Hall, colleges, great recordings, dances, dances, dances, dances, parties, parties. Great event. And so the music was informed by all these levels. That's the beginning of kind of trying to come to terms with what we're talking about. I'm sorry if I'm a little scattershot here because I'm merging, like you Monk, I've been teaching a long time and I have like, you know, these things that I do.

MR: Active resources.

LS: But they're not really coalescing here but somehow, so when I say there's nothing to understand about jazz, so then you have some responsibility also on the part of the musicians. Now a musician might say, a jazz musician might say, when Vladimir Horowitz comes out to play, or the Juilliard String Quartet, they don't go to the microphone and say, I hope you like this little tune by Schubert, you know when he wrote it I have a funny story about it and all that kind of — so they just play. But by mimicking the behavior or not necessarily explaining what they're doing to the audience, or acting in a way that kind of projects an exclusivity or non-inclusion, or being too hip for the room, then you start to get kind of masochistic people who actually enjoy being treated either rudely or curtly by a band. And it's all complicated. And I actually don't have the answer but I can just throw out these various observations and maybe someone — if I thought about it I could kind of make it cohesive.

MR: When we do Part Two of this interview, we'll reflect on that.

LS: Okay.

MR: Lot of food for thought there.

LS: Yep.

MR: Okay. Let me get back to your bio a bit. Was it, the Benny Goodman association, did it take some getting used to with Benny?

LS: Well what happened was I went to Manhattan School of Music in 1976. Music theory major, piano minor. And eventually switched to saxophone major, which means that I got to study with Joe Allard, who was a great teacher, a guy named Dave Tofani, but at the same time, Manhattan School of Music is in the old Juilliard building. It's up at 122nd Street and Claremont Avenue in Manhattan. And just down the street from where I was living was a club called the West End that was run by Phil Schaap. And this is a major moment. I mean I hope somebody, you know, writes a monograph or a thesis on what Phil Schaap did at the West End Café in the 1970s. Because what he did was, people like, well I won't name names, but there were great musicians from the Fletcher Henderson, Count Basie, Jay McShann bands, who were working as bank guards or working as literally messengers on Wall Street, just you know, walking around like the bag I had around their neck and delivering stock things. I mean they were not making a living in music and they were struggling. So what Phil did was Phil put together seven nights a week of jazz at the West End. Jo Jones one day. Harold Ashby the next night. Sammy Price the next night. Eddie Durham, Francis Williams, Ram Ramirez, guys who played with Louis Armstrong you probably never heard of. George James. Drummers like Percy Brice and, and Sonny Greer. I got to work with Sonny Greer there. And what Phil — I mean not only was it musically fascinating because my God there's like these giants of a past era, they're playing right there every night, you can hang out and listen. But also he gave them a social life. In other words for a musician who had played with Count Basie or Duke Ellington or Erskine Hawkins or one of those great bands, to know that Thursday night I'm putting on my suit, I'm getting my horn out, I'm going to play, and this crazy guy, this crazy Phil Schaap guy who knows everything that there ever was about jazz, he's going to be there and he's going to know that I played the solo on this alternate take of "King Porter Stomp." You know that meant so much to these people. It was a profound thing. And so I lived around the corner. The first two years, I mean Manhattan School of Music had no dormitories. So we lived in apartments mostly owned by old ladies who were known to the school that they could tell your parents oh he's going to be rooming with Mrs. Ashe and she's had students for thirty years and she's very safe and all this kind of stuff. So I lived at an apartment at 112th and Riverside Drive that was just around the corner from the West End. And you know I was so desp — not desperate, I was desperate to sit in and to play, and they see a young guy come in with a saxophone oh my God it's going to be another these guys that doesn't know the songs. And so one night there was a group led by Francis Williams. Now Francis Williams is someone

Wilder. In other words classically trained, read flyspecks, and even more than Joe, he was different than Joe, he was not the soloist, the great personal soloist that Joe was. He played great, fine solos. But he was like a Snooky Young or Al Killian or he was like a dynamite lead player. And he had a band with Eddie Durham. And I was so desperate to sit in with him I just took out my saxophone one night and, during a break, to show them like that I wasn't going to muck it up, and I played a little and they said okay you can sit in. And this began a long association with Eddie Durham that was profound for me on many, many levels — musically but also fifty percent culturally. And so what happened was while I was at Manhattan School of Music switching to saxophone major, some great musicians were around there: Ted Rosenthal was in school, a guy named Roy Gerson, Manny Mendelson, other names will come back to me — some really, really fine players were in school at that time. You mentioned about studying before going to college, college before college. Well this was even more. So Eddie Durham had a quartet and I wound up playing in his quartet in a small town up in the Catskills called Goshen, New York, Exit 124 off of Route 6 and Route 17. And I wound up playing there for years, maybe three or four years with him on the weekends. So his band was all people like him, older musicians, a drummer named Harold Austin, who had been the drummer with Jonah Jones's quartet and had been in Harlem since the 30s, a wonderful piano player named Kelly Owens who was on Big Maybelle and those early like, early R&Bish kind of records, and there I was this little kid, 18, 19, but playing night after night after long set after long set, just exposed to these sounds. I mean Eddie Durham was the guy who created, you know, the modern Benny Moten band and the Count Basie band and I mean in terms of the arrangements. And he was also a pioneer on the electric guitar, and he played the electric guitar in that band too. And so just to wrap this one thing up, but the other part of it, besides the music was, and this gets back to another early question of yours about sociological versus musicological. Here I am an 18-year-old kid Jewish kid from the suburbs, and I'm being welcomed into this world of these African-American musicians who are sixty and seventy and who they're staying with, and how people treat one another, and all I can say is like I was so — I mean I could get very emotional now and I'm not going to, but they were so warm and loving and accepting and encouraging in every way that I experienced something about a world that like I didn't know about. It wasn't like my world, not to put my world down. And I used to think all the time about the inverse — well meaning white liberal people who might take in someone as I was to them into their midst and wrap their arms around them. I don't think it would have been the same. I don't think it would have been the same. And as I got older and started to reflect after decades and years about all those things and what those people went through

that's a dangerous thing to do, to generalize. All I can talk about is the people that I was with. And I experienced things and the music, and that's I mean I didn't realize it then. I'm just starting to realize it now. But the music was all part of that. The music is not just something — I've just come to realize this recently at sixty, but you know the music is not just something that happens on the bandstand with C7 and A7 and an old Lester Young solo. You know. The music is something that comes out of the life and out of the experience and out of all these things. Boy do I wish I had learned that lesson a lot earlier in life. But now I can look back and see all that, and how I was the beneficiary of that, and that kind of — no pun intended — colored my way of understanding things. So that was a tremendously significant thing while I was in college.

MR: Well that explains I think partly one of your answers early on today with the sociology and the musicology. And I can also see why you spend so much preparation time with your jazz history class, not to just start out with a person, okay here we go, Louis Armstrong and move forward.

LS: And understanding who Nick Payton is. You know what I mean. Or who Wynton Marsalis is. Or whom you are or I am or any of these people are. When you start to put it in that context. So that happened in those years. And then in the meantime I had mentioned Russ Connor before and *BG on the Record* and the Benny Goodman biodiscography. So I had been very much pursuing that stuff too, collecting records, and I was doing radio shows in college and all this kind of stuff, like a lot of us did. And because I knew Hank Jones as an idol and as somebody who my parents loved and who would get me into gigs to see, I was actually around backstage at some Benny Goodman concerts with Urbie Green and Benny and Bucky Pizzarelli and Hank and all those people, just as a kid, just sitting there just quiet — I don't know how quiet I was, but just sitting there kind of looking and never in a million years thinking that I could play with them but that I was just lucky to be there. And so there was a little more of a connection around the Benny Goodman circle of things. Scott Hamilton had come to New York at that time and was just unbelievable. I mean that's another fascinating thing what Scott did and his band of musicians. And then, in my fourth year of college, I got a call from Benny Goodman and I mean I felt like saying, I mean, "This is Benny Goodman" and I was going to say I'm Artie Shaw and hang up the phone. And it turns out that he was donating his music library to the New York Public Library. And he had contacted Russ Connor, the guy who wrote the book about him, and he said Russ, I need someone to write the accompanying I think they call it a provenance or something, the accompanying monograph or little book about these arrangements. In other words when were they written and what key were they in and were they recorded. And Russ, who worked at the

kid in New York you know, who you know is always collecting your records. Maybe he might know. And he's a musician. So I left school. I don't have a bachelor's degree. I'm one of the rare people who wound up teaching in the master's — I taught in the graduate school of the school I never graduated from, which I guess you can't do anymore, right?

MR: No you can't.

LS: You've got to have a doctorate to do anything. But anyway, I left school and went to work for Benny Goodman. And he was paying me I think it was $250 a week to come in and my job was to say — you know to have a stack of arrangements and you would say now there's three versions of the "King Porter Stomp" here. Now one's in — two are in D flat, there's one in G, and this one has Fletcher Henderson's name on it but this one doesn't but it says Ziggy on the trumpet part or something like that. And so I mean it was just a dream come true. That lasted, I forget how long, a few months. And I wrote this little thing and the music went to the New York Public Library and that was it. So in New York at that time I mean this is 1980, and already you know I could make a living, I mean, playing in just a million different bands, you know what it was like, you know, Stan Rubin's band one night and then filling in at Eddie Condon's maybe one night and then a wedding that paid more money than all of it put together, a bar mitzvah then, playing solo piano in a restaurant and then playing with a million different bands, you know for cheap money. But it all added up and I was 21, 22 years old, what the hell you know. So that was the end of that. Now I had done my first concert, again with my family, my parents put up the money for it, although it did turn a profit, and in June 1979 I guess I was just about to turn 21, I produced a concert at Carnegie Recital Hall and it was called "A Tribute to Bird and Prez." And we played the Super Sax arrangements and then I orchestrated these Lester Young solos for a sax section and myself. And the featured soloists were Howard McGhee, who I had already been working with a little bit, Warren Vache, Eddie Bert, Dickie Wells, Joe Albany, I was already in his quartet. Joe Albany on piano. He had just come back to New York and was healthy for a short time, Herb Ellis, a bass player I was working with named Peck Morrison who was in the Duke Ellington band, and Mel Lewis, who I'd started a friendship with on drums. So that was June 1979. We got reviewed in the *New York Times*, you know, which was not a bad review by John S. Wilson. So I was kind of building up, you know, starting to have a chance to do some of this stuff. Then when I stopped working for Benny I just went back to playing and whatever, but when I was going through his big band music in the course of working on this thing, I asked him if I could copy a few arrangements. I really didn't know why I was going to copy them. Well I think I might have had an inkling. And so he let me copy some music on the Xerox machine, just, I don't know, five or six

to play if you loved swing music and loved big band music, the only way to play it in 1979 or '80 for a young musician was in these kind of like second rate bands that played stock arrangements or transcriptions and you might have three or four really great players in the band and some others that weren't so great. It was a lot of fun and it paid. But it was not at all excellent playing. So one of those bands was a band led by a guy named Bob January. And the singer in his band was Barbara Lea. And we became friends. And I was such a pain in the neck I guess at these rehearsals that Bob said, "Man, you know, you're — why don't you lead the band?" You know, that kind of thing, you know, screw you, that kind of thing. And I stood up you know and I'm going to lead the band and whatever. And I found out that — we were playing, I'll never forget we were playing a stock arrangement of "920 Special." And it turns out that there were four trumpets, the fourth trumpet player had a different stock arrangement. And they had been playing it for twenty years. And it was almost the same but a little bit different. And so I guess whoever played the fourth trumpet part would just modify it by listening. I said, "Can I see that part for a moment?" I thought this is the wrong arrangement. Well to jump, I decided to put together a big band. And I brought with me Robbie Scott was the drummer and Barbara Lea was singing and I must say I put together a band. I mean I started a rehearsal band. And I had some more music I had copied from Benny Goodman and then other people started to — I started to get some charts from different people — copies of this, I mean people like Bill Shremp and Dean Pratt and some other people who were also big band people and they had music. And we started to rehearse and it started to sound pretty good and as I mentioned I'd known, I forget how but I had met Mel Lewis. And I remember asking a friend, saying man I wonder if I could ask Mel to come down and rehearse. Well if you're going to ask Mel, I mean for Christ's sake, I mean he has his own band at the Vanguard. He said, "Well the worst he can do is say no." So he came down, he made a rehearsal. I called some really good charts. And everybody in the band, I mean John Parisi was playing trumpet, Dick Sudhalter, a wonderful trombone player named Eph Resnick — E-P-H — you can look him up in the discographies. Bobby Pring, Bob Kindred, Akira Omori and I'm trying to think of who else you might know — some really really great players. Frank Tate played bass, and the drummer was Fred Stahl. Really great players. Well Mel came down and sat in, liked it and said I'll come back next week. Well when Mel said he would come back next week, and no one's getting paid, I mean I'm paying for the rehearsal space and taping all the music and copying all the charts, but I loved it. I had nothing else to do. When Mel started making it then all of a sudden well Danny Bank wants to play. Or, you know, or Eddie Bert, or Paulie Cohen or whomever. So I started to assemble a band that was a mixture of Doug Lawrence and

players and — it was about fifty percent young and fifty percent older, of course much — the old guys were younger than I am now. And so the band started to cotton. And in the meantime Goodman asked me to come back because this woman I had mentioned before, Muriel Zuckerman, who had been his Girl Friday, she quit, and he said, "Can you come in and just, until I find someone, answer the phones or just help with something?" So I started doing that, and then eventually when he found out that I knew musicians and I had a band, "Well can you recommend somebody?" And do you know, and he started to trust me. And then he started to say well you can go ahead and book the band, or can you write these checks, or can you answer this letter to so-and-so. What the hell? I mean it doesn't take a lot of brains to write a letter you know. So I started, and I wound up becoming his personal manager I guess is what you would call it. Some people, you might question that. What does that mean, a personal manager? Benny Goodman didn't have an agent. He didn't need an agent. What happened in Benny Goodman's office was he got a thousand offers a year to play. I mean people just calling him. He had no agent. It was just call the office of Benny Goodman, "Hello?" Yes I'm so-and-so from the Pori Jazz Festival in Finland and we'd like Mr. Goodman to play on August 9th and we can offer X amount of dollars. So I would assemble all the offers and he would pick which ones he wanted to do. We hired the band, and he had a travel agent. So this all started. Well in the meantime this band that I had put together, we started getting some gigs, I mean for $5 each or I would pay for it or something with the money I was making playing. And we started playing at a place called the Red Blazer Two which was on Third Avenue and 88th Street. And boy the band was really good and I was getting more charts. Johnny Carisi gave me some charts and then I had gotten to know Benny Carter through Ed Berger, and I got a handful of some copies of some Benny Carter charts, and just a whole bunch of other stuff. And early Ellington things at that time. And we made a record. And well and I want to mention one other name and it sounds like a storybook but it's really true, John Hammond, who was Benny Goodman's brother-in-law, and they were not talking and I can tell you about that if you're curious about why that was. He was, you know, he was the guy — I mean he discovered Bruce Springsteen and George Benson and Aretha Franklin and all these people. I mean he brought them to fame. But at this time in the early 80s I mean, you know I mean he still loved big bands, he loved jazz and I guess in the 30s or 40s if John Hammond came to your gig that was you were going to be the next Count Basie or something like that. By 1980, in the early 80s, like who's this old guy. Well he still loved big bands. And I met him, well through Goodman's office because he wasn't talking to Benny at that time and there were some things I had to work around. And I invited him to come hear the band. And he brought Buck Clayton with him. So

Later on, as the band got professional and as I started to make a living in music, all those guys, I mean I paid. I paid for arrangements. I paid arrangers and I paid — but at this time there was nothing there. So John Hammond and a few other things and things started, and next thing you know we're going to make a record. So we made a record for a guy named Jerry Valburn who issued a lot of radio broadcasts with like a big jazz collector who had his own little labels. And he had a label and he started recording and stuff, so I was going to make a big band record for him, if I could pay for the band and he would put it out. So we did a record, it was called "That's The Way It Goes" in 1984, and the band on that record was Dick Katz, Howard Alden, Phil Flanigan, Mel Lewis, Bobby Pring, Eddie Bert and Matt Finders, or maybe Bobby Pring missed as he was on tour with the Widespread Depression band, and my sax section was already set — it was set for a while. Chuck Wilson and Jack Stooky on altos, Ken Peplowski and Doug Lawrence on tenors, and Danny Bank. And the trumpets were, on that first album, Paulie Cohen, Laurie Frink, Dick Sudhalter and John Eckert. And so that was the band. We made this record. It was pretty damn good. We did it at the old RCA studios. I mean it was the old RCA studios on tape with a legendary engineer named Bob Simpson. And it was really, really great. So we made the record and I gave a copy to Goodman, who I was working for still at that time. And I said, "Here's my record." Because we recorded a few of his things. He never said a word about it. Man, he never said like it's good, it's bad. And I'm 25 years old or whatever, I'm dying for him to say something. You know, tell me something. And then the way it worked was Goodman's office, his office and his apartment were in a building called the Manhattan House which is on East 66th Street between Second and Third Avenues. He had the penthouse on Third Avenue, and on the Second Avenue side of the building was a little one bedroom apartment that was his office. So I would go to work in the office, he'd be up in his penthouse on the other avenue over here, and he would call and say, you know, bring the checks up or I'm meeting someone for lunch, or can you come up and have lunch there's nobody, you know. And so we kind of went back and forth. He started calling me from his apartment with my record playing in the background, but he didn't say anything. You know. I don't know if that's what you call passive-aggressive or I don't know what the word is but he was messing with me. And I'd hear my record in the background. And of course I'm dying to say well, well, but I wouldn't, I wouldn't give in you know. Well finally one day, I mean this anecdote sounds improbable, and it is improbable. He lived in Stamford, Connecticut on Rock Rimmon Road. And his girlfriend at that time, his wife had died, his girlfriend was a woman named Carol Phillips, who ran Clinique, which is a woman's make-up like stuff you know? And you know, make-up and perfume and hand cream and

he had a Mercedes. So on some weekends I would actually drive Benny up with Carol to their house, like the chauffeur, drive them up to Stamford, leave them, then I would drive his car back and park it in his garage. And I mean I had never driven a Mercedes Benz but that's another story. Drive it back, park it in his garage, and somehow they would get back on Sunday. Well one time I went up there and one time I went up there and he invited me for lunch and one time he said let's go swimming, he had a swimming pool. Okay you know so we went swimming. And while we were swimming he told me that he was going to hire my band. Because what happened was Dick Hyman had been approached by public television because it was the Fiftieth Anniversary of Benny's breakthrough, 1985. And they wanted to do a public television show. So Dick Hyman was going to put together a band of Jimmy Maxwell and all the guys, Hymie Shertzer , Toots Mondello, and all the guys that were still alive, and all the great musicians, and frankly Benny didn't want to see them anymore. And I don't think they really wanted to see him. It was not a warm relationship between those people unfortunately, for the most part. Some loved him but most didn't. And so he told Dick Hyman and PBS, "I'm not going to do it with a reunion band." Then he heard my band and he wound up hiring my band and we became the last Benny Goodman Orchestra. So he started rehearsing it and changing, and that's a whole nother story. I don't know how much you want to get into it. But that was a whole thing seeing him rehearse Fletcher Henderson and all those arrangements. Got rid of Mel Lewis, didn't want Mel Lewis so we had Louie Bellson. He wanted Bob Haggart on bass. So we put Bob Haggart and Louie Bellson in the band, and Dick Hyman took the place of Dick Katz. But outside of that I mean it was the same band that I had had. And boy was it a lesson for me, seeing what a great band leader can do to what was a very good band, and then turn it into the sparkling, shining Benny Goodman Orchestra. And then I joined the great legion of people who were let go of a Benny Goodman band. My own band.

MR: Your own band.

LS: I was gone. My place was taken by Ted Nash. And I'll say now, you know, thirty-five years, thirty-four years retrospect, Ted's a better section player than I am you know. But that was a life lesson, you know what I mean? And then Benny died the following June and I mean I kept doing gigs with the band anyway, when I had gigs, and Benny passed away and then I decided soon after there that this was not going to be a Benny Goodman ghost band. I mean (a) his estate eventually said there will be no ghost band. But I really had no desire to go down the road like some other band leaders did. I mean I played Carnegie Hall with Bob Wilber on the Fiftieth Anniversary of the Carnegie Hall concert. I had no desire to go down that (a) I don't play the clarinet, (b) without Ken Peplowski or

that many who you'd want to hear play a Benny Goodman concert, because it would suck. I mean there are a handful, but not that many. And I didn't know them you know. So I gave that up and then started recording our own albums and we did four or five albums for MusicMasters. And they were nice combinations of, I mean I'm no great arranger. I can arrange — the most arranging I ever did was for Bobby Short during the years when I had his band. But with my own big band, no. I mean I wanted much better writers than me. So eventually James Chirillo and Mark Lopeman and Mike Christiansen arranged, plus Mel and others who were in the band said you know when Benny took the band to Moscow in 1962 he commissioned Tadd Dameron and Bob Brookmeyer and Johnny Carisi and a few other people to write all this great music, the majority of which never was recorded. So we started recording those things. And we made a series of records starting in 198- well the first one was '84 then the second version of the band in 1987 through, for about ten years we made a record every couple of years. Eventually Steve Wilson came in the band and other great players. So anyway that's —

MR: Well you are one of the luckiest guys in the world then.

LS: Yes I am.

MR: We've been at this for quite a while, so we're going to have to do Part Two, but I wanted to ask you about the Jazz Museum in Harlem. Did you have to interview for that position, and did you give them a philosophy, a pitch so to speak?

LS: In the early 1990s I started to branch out a little bit more. I was involved with something called the American Jazz Orchestra, with John Lewis, that started in 1985, 1986. And this was a band comprised of mostly big band veterans: Marvin Stamm, Virgil Jones, John Eckert, Benny Powell, Jimmy Knepper, Eddie Bert, I think I said him, Danny Bank and Jerry Dodgion and Jerome Richardson and Bill Easley and Dick Katz and great bass players including we made a record with Ron Carter and Howard Collins on guitar. It was a great band. And we started doing concerts down at Cooper Union, and this was a chance where John Lewis who was an absolute idol of mine, as he would be for most anybody. Because I loved his piano playing so much. On top of everything else. And that band lasted about maybe eight years or so. Gary Giddins was the artistic director. And we made a series of recordings. Probably the best known one would be "Central City Sketches" with Benny Carter and this was when Benny, at the age of 79 or 80, came out of retirement and wrote a suite and recorded it and when it came out on an album it created quite a bit of buzz. It was a great record. "Central City Sketches." Then we also recorded the music of Duke Ellington for Nesuhi Ertegun on Atlantic Records where I had to play all the Ben Webster things. And the music of Jimmy Lunceford and maybe one more record. So that took up a lot of my time. And at that point I started to become

would conduct when John wasn't there. Then Mel Lewis had been working for years with what they call the Westdeutscher Rundfunk, which is the radio orchestra in Cologne Germany. And he got me on that. So for two summers I conducted that orchestra in Cologne. Did the "Rhapsody in Blue" and there's a funny story about that with Gunther Schuller. And the "Rhapsody in Blue" and the Paul Whiteman program with the full arrangements for the strings and all this kind of stuff. And did another concert with Milt Grayson who had sung with Duke Ellington's band, and Lynn Roberts. And then another repertory band started called the Smithsonian Jazz Orchestra. And the conductors of that were Gunther Schuller and David Baker. And I was hired originally to be the contractor, to be the tenor soloist and to be kind of like the third conductor. That didn't really happen. I wound up becoming the substitute conductor, when Gunther or David couldn't make it. And that band lasted a long — that band is still going but my days in it were about maybe ten years or so. And there I got to meet a whole nother tranche of sorry — another tranche of big band veterans and people that weren't in New York who I didn't get to know, and there were all these other wonderful musicians. So at that point I started to lose the impetus after ten or fifteen years of having my own big band and of copying all those parts. I mean I used to, before Jazz at Lincoln Center started all that stuff, I mean I still have a dent in my finger, a guy named Mark Tucker, who was a wonderful Ellington scholar. He edited the *Ellington Reader*. He was the one who prepared the Ellington big band, the Ellington musical library that eventually went to the Smithsonian, that is now, John Hasse got it at the Smithsonian. And he gave me Xeroxed copies of, I mean a file cabinet's worth of handwritten Ellington scores. So I started transcribing those for my band, which was a great lesson. And I'm trying to get my — with this finger right here — with the old pencil and the old thing, and even with my students now when I have them do kind of writing assignments, I kind of insist, as much as I can, that they do it by hand. I mean all the computer, that's great and that's what they're going to do. But you are going to write out this Ellington thing by hand, the third alto part, looking at the concert score and saying okay it's G sharp and all that kind of stuff. Because you learn so much more. So I started having, I stopped having like the impetus to have my own band. Plus I was teaching, I started teaching at the New School in 19— well I worked with Sylvia Sims, a great singer, and her trio was Fred Hirsch and Steve Wispina and myself. And Fred was teaching at the New School. This would have been around 1990. And he said man, would you like to fill in and sub, I can't make it. I said well what's the class? Well some kind of like styles analysis, but you can do whatever the hell you want. So I went in and I really enjoyed it. And so I called Fred back and I said would you mind if I call up Martin Mueller, the head of the program, and like pitched my soul for a class? But

please if you want, take my class, I really don't care. I don't have time for it right now. So I called up and I started designing my own classes there, which would cover kind of like Ellington and Brahms, and I would take them through a Brahms symphony for a month or two, and then an Ellington extended work, and look for the intersections in terms of the narrative structure of composition and orchestration. I was teaching myself this stuff and getting paid for it. In the very first class at the New School for doing this, I brought in a Brahms string quartet, this kid sat down at the piano — and you know the string quartets with the alto clef and all the funny clefs, just, it was Brad Meldeau. And he just sat down and kind of sight read this. So I said if this is a typical student you know my God. Well that led to eventually teaching at Manhattan School of Music. I took that course over there for graduate students and I was there for about ten years. I mean on my epitaph it should say "Loren Schoenberg, Adjunct to the World." You know? Because I taught at every school, never a full time faculty, never health coverage or anything. But anyway, I taught there for a long time. And then at the same time I was doing I mean I had done radio. I mean I had done college radio. And then I wound up kind of becoming a fill in radio announcer at WGBO because there was a show called "Jazz from the Archives" with Dan Morgenstern and Ed Berger and Vincent Pelote. And I was kind of like an adopted son or something. So I started doing these shows with them. No money, but a lot of fun and interviewing people but doing a lot of historical shows. And that led to Kenny Washington was hired by Sirius Satellite Radio to take over all these jazz programming in the early days of satellite radio. So Kenny, I mean this is another untold story but he did such a job of digitizing thousands of pieces of Swing Era jazz and 50s era jazz too. And he created a database, this is before people knew what they were doing. He didn't do it himself but he dictated to a computer guy at Sirius to have the computer program music based on an algorithm of tempo, key, if it modulates, you know, major, minor, big band, small band, so you press a button and you've got the greatest sets of music you ever heard in your life with all these weird juxtapositions but that made for great changes of tempo and key all the time. So I was doing that. And you asked a question about the Jazz Museum and we're just going to get there now.

MR: Okay.

LS: So to put it all together, so I was teaching at Manhattan, doing the Sirius Satellite Radio show, Juilliard was just about to start a jazz program, and I was going to teach there. And in 1997 I became Bobby Short's musical director. So Bobby had had a trio for many, many years, famously, at the Café Carlyle. And we were in the wings once at Jazz at Lincoln Center on the benefit concert, we were both appearing. And I jokingly said, because I knew him through a woman named Jean Bach, and they were very good

jokingly, I said like, “Hey man” I said, “you know, you know what you need, you need a big band.” I said, like I did for, you know, like I said, joking, a big band with Bobby Short. Well I got a phone call from him about six months later saying, “You know you mentioned a band and you know, I can’t afford a big band.” I said, “I was just joking, Bobby, Jesus, you know.” He said, “Well I’ll tell you what, I have one gig” at some hotel, not the Carlyle but like a one night off gig, and I have some charts, and I’ve never really heard them, would you put — so I put together six horns, two trumpets, a trombone and three reeds. And we did this gig at some hotel here in Midtown, and the arrangements were really cheesy. They were really like what you would call like hotel band arrangements. Lot of whole notes and the harmonies were all just pudding or you know, vanilla, oatmeal, or whatever you call it. Nothing really there, but it sounded good. They were good arrangements. And that was that. And then he called back and said, “I’m going into the Carlyle in the fall and I think I’d like to try the band for ten weeks” you know, five nights a week, ten weeks, and I’d like to try it but I’m going to need some arrangements, because you know those arrangements I have are really pedestrian. So I started to arrange for the band. And pretty soon found that there were people who do it better than I could but that came a little bit later. So I put together a band. And the band was John Eckert and Virgil Jones, two trumpets, the trombone was split 50/50 between Eddie Bert and Bobby Pring, and the saxophones were myself, Scott Robinson and Jack Stooky or Jay Branford. And we joined Bobby’s trio, he had a bass and drum. And it went well although something funny happened. Bobby used to do a great version of “On the Street of Dreams.” And he asked me to write an arrangement. So I listened to his record, and this was part of why I eventually hired other arrangers. I didn’t realize it but I think subconsciously I was trying to educate him, but I was trying to write a sophisticated arrangement a little beyond what he was doing at the piano and, it was a big error, but I didn’t know it. So I wrote this esoteric arrangement. It wasn’t bad. But it wasn’t as good as the stuff that came later. So we did it. Now the funny thing was at the Carlyle the first season we were there I didn’t know it, the brass was here then there was Bobby and the piano, and over on the other side of the bass, on the other side of the room, were the three reeds. So I wrote an arrangement of “Street of Dreams” with the bass clarinet and trombone, muted trombone, playing some kind of esoteric counter line to Bobby in some kind of harmony. It sounded like, like you know if Anton Webern, you know, was sick, and incapacitated. It was horrible. Atonal, without the other note. So all the people sitting on one side of the room just heard [scats] it was horrible. Well they changed the configuration of the band and we eventually all sat together, and then Mark Lopeman and James Chirillo and Mike Christiansen started writing stuff. And what would happen was

a great pianist. People said oh he rushed or he didn't have a jazz feel. Who cares what he did. He was a brilliant orchestrator. Monk you would love this. He could sit down, like you could ask him to play a tune he hadn't played in thirty years. He'd sit down and he'd play and he'd find his key, and what would come out of the piano would sound like a Billy Strayhorn arrangement. I mean he spontaneously could do that. I mean and he loved Ellington I mean that was his whole life was Ivy Anderson and Duke Ellington and Billy Strayhorn. He grew up with it. He knew them. He knew Ivy Anderson. And he could just create these things, I mean amazing. I would sit sometimes at the Carlyle and we'd be playing an arr — okay so what would happen was eventually Mark Loepman and James began to realize — because I would go to Bobby's house and record him playing and we would talk about the key and the tempo and what he wanted and then we'd arrange — and I'd record it and I'd give a copy of the recording to Mark or to James. And they started telling me you know what? Everything in the arrangement is in the piano. See I was adding things. You don't need to add anything. Orchestrate the piano and you can add a few notes but that's the arrangement. You couldn't come up with something better. So we started playing these arrangements at the Carlyle and I'm sitting like this and Bobby, I'm sitting on a banquette, and Bobby is facing that way at the piano. I'm facing him. And I'm watching him. We wound up doing a — I wound up doing a thousand one-hour shows with him. It was 20 weeks a year for five years. So that's — anyway it was 1000 shows because there were two shows a night. And he started playing on the piano counterpoint to the arrangement that was written of his piano playing, and he could, Monk, he could create two and three levels of counterpoint at the piano. It was not comping like a D flat 7, C minor, it was counterpoint. And he had like this pearly upper register and then he had like this middle thing, and then he had these strange bass notes. And I'd be listening, when I wasn't playing. I thought Jesus, what is he doing? He's spontaneously has three lines. It's almost like the way that Teddy Wilson played with the Benny Goodman trio and quartet. And Teddy Wilson's son once said to me, he said, "You know Benny Goodman should have paid my father triple scale." And I said why? "Because he has three things going on at the piano. He has a left hand, he has a right hand, and he has his thumb." There's three levels of stuff going on. Well anyway, now, so I had all that stuff was going on and that was this incredibly rich part of my life, I mean rich in terms of experience. And it was really great, it was really too much, but I was handling it, I was in my early 40s. Through the Smithsonian Jazz Orchestra and one of the lesser bands I played in I got to know a wonderful classical clarinetist in New York named Paul Garment. And Paul's father was Len Garment, Leonard Garment. And I knew who Len Garment was because he was a fascinating guy, I mean he was known for

explain. But he was a Brooklyn liberal guy who wound up in the Nixon White House and became a real, I guess what you'd call eminence grise in Washington in the 70s days with Pat Moynihan at the U.N. and was a real culturally, he loved culture. And through the mechanisms of Washington and politics of lobbying and politics he wound up doing a lot of great things. The National Endowments for the Arts and Humanities, which were created during the Nixon administration, excuse me, during the Johnson administration, they were very small. When Nixon got into power he brought Len Garment with him. Len became like the Arts Czar in the Nixon years. And he hired a woman named Nancy Hanks. It was under Nancy Hanks that the endowments went from a few hundred thousand dollars or several hundred thousand — to gazillions of tens of millions. That was Len. Also the Duke Ellington birthday party. So a lot of great things happened with Len. Len had a great sense of humor. He was tagged with going out to solve the problem at Wounded Knee with Russell Means and the Native Americans, he met the chief of the Sioux Nation at which he famously said, "That's funny, you don't look Siouxish." But anyway, he had a great sense of humor, and they laughed when he said it. Well anyway Len had the idea to build a national jazz museum. So he got some money from friends in Washington who loved jazz, and they raised a few hundred thousand dollars and said okay, we're going to hire someone up in New York, up in Harlem, and then we're going to somehow get this jazz museum going. Well I heard about this. I knew Len. And I hadn't been invited to participate and that's okay, but I heard about it from Stanley Crouch, I heard about it from, I don't know any number of people I knew saying well we had a meeting on this jazz museum. And okay great. Well to make a long story slightly less long that version of the jazz museum just died. The guy who was leading it, this death by a thousand blows of a 501C3. This consultant, this consultant, and next thing you know the money was gone, they hadn't raised any money, and the project died. So I knew Len and when he would come to New York we'd meet and just listen to him talk, oh his great stories. He wrote a wonderful book by the way, called *Crazy Rhythm*, which Saul Bellow wrote a wonderful little blurb on, I strongly recommend it. Anyway, I met with him at the Carlyle once before going to work with Bobby that night, and he said, "You know this jazz museum thing" he said, "it died, but we just got a million dollars from Congress from Ted Stevens." He was head of appropriations. And we don't have an organization. I don't know what to do. Would you, could you recommend someone who could take this on you know. And it wound up that I said well I'll try it. He said well you can't do it, you're doing all these other things, you don't have time. And I said well I'd like to try. So in May 2001 we opened up our offices, or was it late 2001 or early — in 200- right around 9/11 was when this all came together, and then early 2002 okay the

amount of money. In terms of building a 501C3 and creating an organization in New York City it's like $10 and that's a crazy thing to say but that's the truth. I mean if you're looking at something major. Plus the money came with all kinds of restrictions. Couldn't use it for fundraising, could only use it for the salaries and for research and stuff like that. Well we opened up an office in Harlem and we decided that we needed to aim big so that the genius, the great quality that Len had at that time was, even though we had nothing to show except a desk and a telephone and a board of directors or something like that, he said, "You know what, we're going to shoot big." We're going to build a big museum and we're going to hire the best people, and even though we didn't have the money to do that, 'cause this million dollars, trust me, was going, it was going with this and with that. We're going to hire the best people, and so we had articles in the *New York Times* and the *Wall Street Journal* because of who Len Garment was, for the great aspirations of this organization. And so, let me think of how I can collapse this so it makes sense. I brought Wynton Marsalis and Ken Burns on board. I'd been working with Wynton at Jazz at Lincoln Center just as a consultant or as an educator and I had participated as one of the consultants on the Ken Burns Jazz series. So they agreed to join the board, even though we didn't have anything, and it was a great thing for Wynton because of course he has his own organization that he has to raise money for. So people started saying well, you've got these great plans, I had written the NPR *Curious Listeners' Guide to Jazz* in 2001. We took that book and with a lot of other opinions created an exhibit model for the museum for a 50,000 square foot museum. We hired a guy named Ralph Appelbaum, who designed the Clinton Library and the Civil Rights Museum and paid him a huge chunk of that money that we had gotten and spent two years designing what a 50,000 square foot museum would look like. The exhibits, the this, who would be in the exhibits, what the, all the interstitial stuff and this kind of stuff. In the meantime people started saying but what are you actually doing? You're planning but what the hell are you doing? I can't give money to an organization that's planning to be big someday. So we started doing public programming. And that became the tail that wagged the dog or whatever that expression is. It just started almost as an afterthought and it became who we are and who we still are. Oral histories, hundreds of them, with Kareem Abdul-Jabbar or Bobby Short or Roy Haynes or Clark Terry or Chico Hamilton or Billy Taylor, or just I mean name all the people. But also significantly, the lesser known people.

MR: Yeah. That's important.

LS: And not only the lesser known jazz people, of whom we interviewed more than not, but also people on the periphery of jazz. Architects. Newspaper columnists. Doctors. People who had a fascinating jazz story to tell. And we did these in public in our little office. I

of that came all of the other programs: Jazz for Curious Listeners, and Jazz for Curious Readers, and I can't even remember them all. And then we started producing a concert series at the Rubin Museum of Art called Harlem in the Himalayas. Because the Rubin Museum of Art is dedicated to the culture of the Himalayas.

MR: I've often wondered about that.

LS: Yeah, yeah. Well the way it happened was there was a man named Donald Rubin who made a lot of money in health insurance. And he had more money than he knew what to do with. And he was nuts about, he was dedicated to Himalayan and culture and spirituality. So he built this vanity museum down on 18th Street I believe it is, off of Seventh Avenue, and he hired all the right people and got a brilliant programmer or a brilliant designer, and his vanity project wound up becoming one of the hippest, smartest, most popular museums in Manhattan. I mean who'd of thought that it might happen. So I went down to meet him because Len had met him at the urologist's office, and started to pitch a program to him and he said, "What should we call it?" I said, "Harlem in the Himalayas." And he said, "What does that mean?" I said, "I have no idea." And this program went on for several years, it won some awards for best programming, and I'm proud of it. If you look at it, we must have done 150 concerts or something like that. And the idea was that whoever came down, whether it was Dizzy Reese or whether it was Jack Walrath or whether it was, I mean, I can't even start to name the names, all kinds of young contemporary musicians and famous people from other countries, the idea was that one of the tunes that you played would relate to the Himalayan exhibits in the museum. Either you'd write a tune, I mean I remember one guy came in and played "Caravan" but that was a one-off. That never happened again. Or as Kenny Davern used to say, "CarAvan." Did you interview him?

MR: Yes indeed.

LS: Oh boy do I miss him, I wish he was around. But anyway, yeah, Kenny told me, he said one time he was on one of those jazz cruises and they told the band, you know, you'll eat with the customers, everything. Well of course every time they went to eat in the restaurant they never got called. Their table never got called. And so there they are with all these great guys and they're just ignoring him so he told me he says, "Man I went up to the microphone to announce and I said, 'Christ, party of 12.'" Anyway so the Rubin Museum of Art, so the museum slowly grew, I mean for a long time it was just me and one other person, and then two other people, and then eventually it got to the point where we had three people. And then eventually we got to the point where I realized that I was not the right person anymore. I mean I was writing the checks and opening the door and putting up the chairs, and at some point, like we really needed, especially if we wanted to

this wonderful. There's two people, boy, they do everything you know. Who wants to give real money to that? So the board and I decided you know it was time to really hire an administrator, administrative staff, and now we have a full time staff of four or five, a great administrator, a lot of consultants, and our artistic directors are John Bastiste and Christian McBride. And we're about to enter our third decade.

MR: In a new building, right?

LS: We moved to a new building about 2-1/2 years ago and it's spanking new and great. We just have a large one room, but we have some great collections. We have Ralph Ellison's the recordings that he listened to when he was writing "Invisible Man."

MR: Wow.

LS: We have that. We have Eddie "Lockjaw" Davis's tenor sax and I went out to his family's house in Las Vegas, all his things. So his reeds and his matchbook covers from Birdland, and the album that his mother made when he was a kid. We have the Savory Collection which are unissued recordings going back to the 1930s and 40s. We have a handful of collections like that that are very very special.

MR: So I'm going to make a proposal that when I do Part Two with you I'll come down and we'll do it there in the aura would be there and I'll get to see your things.

LS: Yeah. Well only on one condition.

MR: Yeah?

LS: If I can interview you for our archives.

MR. Okay.

LS: Because your archive is unique, and as I told you before, we filmed and I think it's the second time I'm using the word unctuous, but I'm not trying to be unctuous but you know what you've done consistently for a quarter of a century is invaluable and unique. Yes there are other archives or other interviews and we all know them. But you have create a finite thing based on what seems to be your personal thing with the people that you interview somehow, and some of them I can tell you are friends with and some maybe you never met before, but they're informal and like I told you recently I mean Buddy DeFranco, I went back and just started checking out some of your — and as soon as I started checking out your Buddy DeFranco interview it sent me to 15 records of his and other things, and then he talked about this and then so and so. And you know he said it's funny when we had whoever here, he mentioned something about something and I'd go and watch that one. And I'm looking forward to your interviews being placed at someplace where they'll be accessible — well they are accessible.

MR: They are on YouTube now.

LS: Absolutely. But even beyond YouTube. Because it's a unique thing and it was an

MR: Well I appreciate this.

LS: And we look at ours as kind of complementary to yours.

MR: Yeah.

LS: And so if I can interview you then I'll do another one.

MR: Okay. Sounds like a plan.

LS: Okay.

MR: And I'm glad to have you part of ours.

LS: Oh I'm really happy to be part of it.

MR: Okay.

LS: Thank you.

MR: All right. Thanks a lot.